

Experience of the hackathon

The 36-hour AI Hackathon at NIT Trichy pushed our team to move from idea to a working prototype under real time pressure. Working on DrowsyGuard, we spent the first stretch nailing down the core detection pipeline — getting MediaPipe's facial landmarks talking to our EAR/PERCLOS logic — then iterated hard on making the alert escalation feel right rather than just technically correct. Debugging real-time camera performance at 2 AM taught us more about edge cases than any tutorial could. The mentors' feedback rounds were a highlight — sharp, specific questions that forced us to defend design choices like why we went with on-device processing over cloud inference. By the final demo, seeing the three-tier alert system actually catch simulated drowsiness in real time made the sleepless stretch worth it. Overall, it was an intense but genuinely rewarding sprint that sharpened both our technical execution and our ability to build under deadline pressure as a team.